

CHOSEN: THE STORY BEFORE THE MANGER

SCENE 5 - BROTHERHOOD

COMPANY VERSION

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SCENE 5 — BROTHERHOOD

Approximate Running Time: 4½–5 minutes

Musical Sequence: “Brotherhood” — approximately 1½–2 minutes

Characters: JOSEPH, LEVI, MALACHI, CALEB, EZRA, MARY, SHIRA

TRANSITION FROM SCENE 4

Scene 4 ends somewhere else in Nazareth with the dangerous echo: 'That's what I heard.'

One beat.

BANG!

A hammer strikes wood.

BANG!

A second strike.

BANG-BANG!

Lights cut to Joseph's work area. The tonal shift should be immediate: warmth, laughter, physical energy.

JOSEPH, LEVI, MALACHI, CALEB, and EZRA are already working together. The unfinished table from Scene 2 is now unmistakably the project.

The satchel Mary made Joseph is on him. Do not feature it yet.

A hand slaps a workbench.

Suddenly—

JOSEPH'S WORLD.

Bright.

Alive.

Rhythmic.

JOSEPH, LEVI, MALACHI, CALEB and EZRA are already working.

They do not stand in a line.
The worksite is constantly moving;
wood passes from hand to hand;
tools change owners;
measurements are called;
benches move;
pieces are lifted;
someone climbs;
someone ducks;
someone catches something at the last second.
Everything feels practiced.
These men have worked together for years.

WORK BEFORE WORDS

Do not begin with dialogue. Let the audience watch the men work.

Joseph checks a length. Levi takes weight. Ezra checks alignment. Malachi steadies a piece. Caleb tries to help and is just useful enough to remain employed.

The physical vocabulary beneath the sequence is MEASURE -> MARK -> CUT -> SET. It may be expressed through movement rather than repeated as lyrics.

Hammer strikes, scraping wood, footwork, hand-claps, and safe prop percussion begin to align into a musical pulse.

JOSEPH

Hold that.

CALEB

I am holding it.

EZRA

You're leaning on it.

CALEB

That is a form of holding.

LEVI

Move.

Levi takes the weight cleanly.

CALEB

See? Teamwork.

MALACHI

That is not what happened.

CALEB

It's what I experienced.

They keep working. The rhythm continues underneath.

JOSEPH IN HIS ELEMENT

Joseph stops and looks at a piece Caleb has handled.

JOSEPH

Caleb.

CALEB

What?

Joseph points at it.

JOSEPH

Look at it.

Caleb looks.

CALEB

I am.

JOSEPH

And?

Caleb studies it harder.

CALEB

Strong.

JOSEPH

Caleb.

CALEB

Very strong.

Ezra steps over, looks once.

EZRA

One side is higher.

CALEB

Only if you compare it to the other side.

Beat.

LEVI

That's usually how sides work.

Joseph takes the piece from Caleb.

CALEB

You don't trust my work.

JOSEPH

I trust you completely.

Caleb softens, pleased.

CALEB

Thank you.

JOSEPH

Your work is another matter.

The men laugh. Joseph resets the piece, and the music/movement picks back up.

MARRIAGE BANTER

Levi notices Joseph working on another piece.

LEVI

Hold on.

Whose is that?

JOSEPH

Customer's.

EZRA

No.

JOSEPH

No?

EZRA

Different wood.

Different finish.

Ezra watches Joseph inspect the table.

EZRA

And you've checked that corner four times.

CALEB

Four?

He GASPS.

CALEB

Oh, we've lost him.

JOSEPH

I'm standing right here.

LEVI

That's for Mary.

Joseph continues working.

LEVI

Too late. They know.

CALEB

It's for the house!

JOSEPH

Caleb—

CALEB

He's building the house!

LEVI

Man hasn't even married her, and he's already building furniture.

MALACHI

At least he'll have somewhere to sleep after she gets tired of him.

Joseph looks at Malachi.

JOSEPH

You too?

MALACHI

Wisdom comes in many forms.

EZRA

This one appears to be a table.

Joseph stops. Looks at Ezra.

EZRA

What?

It's obviously a table.

CALEB

How big is this thing?

JOSEPH

Big enough.

EZRA

That is not a measurement.

LEVI

Who's sitting at it?

JOSEPH

People.

CALEB

How many people?

JOSEPH

Six.

Ezra looks at the table.

EZRA

That's not a six-person table.

JOSEPH

It might be eight.

Beat.

Caleb slowly turns toward Joseph.

CALEB

Eight?

Joseph keeps working.

CALEB

Joseph.

JOSEPH

What?

CALEB

Eight?

JOSEPH

People visit.

LEVI

Of course.

EZRA

Very small people, apparently.

Caleb realizes.

CALEB

Children.

JOSEPH

I didn't say that.

CALEB

You built it.

The others laugh.

CALEB

How many?

JOSEPH

Caleb.

CALEB

You've counted.

JOSEPH

I have not.

EZRA

He has.

JOSEPH

Ezra.

EZRA

Evidence suggests—

JOSEPH

Nobody asked for evidence.

LEVI

Eight means there's room.

Joseph's defensiveness softens.

JOSEPH

That's the idea.

MALACHI

Room for what?

Joseph looks at the table.

This time he answers without joking.

JOSEPH

Family.

Friends.

Beat.

JOSEPH

Whoever needs a place.

That quiets them for just a moment.

Then—

CALEB

And children.

JOSEPH

Go cut something.

CALEB

Gladly.

Caleb grabs the appropriate piece and launches back into the work.

JOSEPH

Not that one.

Caleb freezes.

CALEB

I knew that.

EZRA

Evidence suggests—

CALEB

Nobody asked for evidence.

The men laugh.

The men laugh and return to the work rhythm. Joseph tries to hide how pleased he is, which only confirms everything.

SATCHEL CONTINUITY

Caleb reaches for a tool and notices Joseph's satchel.

CALEB

You still carrying that?

JOSEPH

It's a tool satchel.

CALEB

Then where are the tools?

Joseph instinctively checks.

The others notice the satchel is nearly empty.

EZRA

Interesting.

JOSEPH

Don't.

CALEB

She made you a satchel, and now you're protecting it from the tools.

JOSEPH

I use it.

LEVI

For what?

Joseph looks at all of them.

JOSEPH

For carrying things.

CALEB

Like feelings?

Joseph throws a rag at Caleb. Caleb catches it triumphantly.

CALEB

See? Now it's useful.

Back into the work.

“BROTHERHOOD” BEGINS

The carpentry pulse now expands into the full Brotherhood sequence.

This should feel rehearsed and exciting, but never disconnected from the work. The men are not presenting choreography to the audience; they are working so instinctively together that the work becomes choreography.

Movement possibilities: passing wood in counter-rhythm; coordinated lifts; safe tool-handling phrases; turns generated by carrying material; foot-stomps; hand-claps; bench/wood percussion; a repeated lift-set-release pattern; Caleb adding unnecessary flourishes that the others repeatedly correct.

Joseph should eventually stop supervising every beat and fully join the physical joy. We need to see him young, competitive, laughing and completely at home with these men.

PERCUSSIVE PATTERN

HAMMER — HAMMER — SAW — CLAP — FOOT

HAMMER — HAMMER — SAW — CLAP — FOOT

The men begin passing tools in rhythm.

Movement becomes sharper.

Angular.

Masculine.

Precise.

The dialogue starts locking into tempo.

LEVI

Measure.

EZRA

Mark.

CALEB

Cut.

MALACHI

Again.

JOSEPH

Lift.

ALL

Set.

BANG!

CALEB

Too high!

EZRA

Too low.

LEVI

Move!

MALACHI

Slow.

JOSEPH

Together.

HIT.

The piece lands perfectly.

RHYTHMIC SPOKEN SECTION

LEVI

If it's heavy—

CALEB

We lift it.

EZRA

If it's crooked—

JOSEPH

We fix it.

MALACHI

If it's broken—

LEVI

We mend it.

CALEB

If it's food—

ALL

CALEB!

CALEB

I was going to say share it.

EZRA

No, you weren't.

The audience laughs.

The work continues.

LEVI

Side by side—

MALACHI

Hand to hand—

EZRA

Know the measure—

JOSEPH

Know the plan—

CALEB

And if the plan goes bad—

Everyone stops.

Looks at Caleb.

CALEB

We blame Ezra.

EZRA

Why me?

CALEB

You look responsible.

The rhythm immediately resumes.

“BROTHERHOOD” — CALL AND RESPONSE

This portion may become sung/spoken/rap-adjacent depending on Christian's composition.

The text can ultimately be shaped musically, but the dramatic territory is:

JOSEPH

You don't build alone.

MEN

No.

LEVI

You don't stand alone.

MEN

No.

MALACHI

When one man loses his footing—

MEN

We hold him.

EZRA

When one man misses the measure—

CALEB

We tell everybody.

EZRA

That's not—

JOSEPH

Caleb!

Laughter inside the rhythm.

Then—

ALL

THE BROTHERHOOD Work together. Stand together. Build together.

BANG!

ALL

Brothers don't let brothers fall.

The phrase should land clearly enough to return emotionally later.

CHOREOGRAPHIC FEATURE

The music expands into approximately 20–30 seconds of instrumental choreography.

This is the major visual payoff of the scene.

MOVEMENT LANGUAGE

Use:

sharp foot patterns;

synchronized stomps;

body percussion;
tool percussion;
bench work;
rhythmic passing of lumber;
jumps over low work pieces where safe;
sliding underneath beams;
controlled vaults by trained performers;
quick level changes;
canon movement;
tight unison sections;
athletic turns;
five-man formations that constantly break and reform.

The choreography should feel as though construction itself has become dance.

One man throws a lightweight piece of wood.

Another catches it on count.

Hammer.

Spin.

Pass.

Duck.

Stomp.

Clap.

BANG!

Joseph lands the last strike.

Silence.

APPLAUSE BUTTON OPPORTUNITY.

Laughter. Breath. The men remain in the world of the workshop rather than posing for applause.

CALEB

That is how you build a table.

EZRA

You contributed almost nothing.

CALEB

Morale.

LEVI

You were the reason morale was necessary.

Caleb considers that.

CALEB

Still counts.

Joseph looks at the table. He is pleased despite himself.

MALACHI

You're happy.

Joseph looks at him.

JOSEPH

Is that a question?

MALACHI

No.

Joseph looks toward the table again, then unconsciously touches or adjusts the satchel.

JOSEPH

Good.

CALEB

That's it?

JOSEPH

What?

CALEB

The man is getting married, building a table for half of Nazareth, and all we get is 'good.'

LEVI

Leave him alone.

CALEB

I am celebrating him.

EZRA

Aggressively.

JOSEPH

I am happy.

That lands. Joseph does not need a speech.

JOSEPH

Very.

The others see that he means it.

THE BROTHERHOOD PROMISE

CALEB

Then remember us when you become respectable.

JOSEPH

Too late for you.

CALEB

Exactly. Someone has to protect you from it.

LEVI

We're finishing this tomorrow.

EZRA

Assuming Caleb does not improve anything overnight.

CALEB

You mock me now.

MALACHI

We mocked you this morning.

CALEB

Consistency. That's brotherhood.

Small laugh.

JOSEPH

When real trouble comes, you'll know the difference.

CALEB

Oh?

JOSEPH

When trouble comes, we stand together.

The line should not become solemn. It is simply true to Joseph in this moment.

LEVI

That, we can agree on.

MALACHI

We can.

EZRA

Within reason.

CALEB

There he goes.

Caleb looks at Ezra and shakes his head. They laugh again.

MARY ARRIVES

The men move back into the work.

The rhythm begins again—easy now. Familiar.

Joseph has his back turned.

At the edge of the space, MARY appears.

SHIRA is with her.

The audience sees them.

The men do not.

Mary watches Joseph laughing with his friends.

Completely happy.

The unfinished table beside him.

The satchel she made him still on his shoulder.

Shira looks at Mary.

SHIRA

You want me to stay?

Mary looks at Joseph.

For a moment, she almost says yes.

MARY

No.

Beat.

MARY

Thank you.

Shira offers her hand. Mary takes it briefly.

SHIRA

Start with the truth.

Mary nods.

Shira moves away but does not need to disappear immediately. Mary is now alone at the edge of Joseph's world.

The men continue working.

CALEB

I'm just saying, eight chairs is a commitment.

JOSEPH

Are you still talking?

CALEB

I have questions.

EZRA

No one doubts that.

LEVI

Leave him alone.

CALEB

I am leaving him alone.

MALACHI

You are standing next to him.

CALEB

Emotionally.

Joseph laughs.

Then he turns.

He sees Mary.

His face immediately lights up.

JOSEPH

Mary!

That warmth should hurt.

Joseph crosses toward her.

JOSEPH

What are you doing here?

Then he sees her face.

His smile doesn't disappear immediately.

Concern replaces it.

JOSEPH

Hey.

Beat.

JOSEPH

What's wrong?

Mary tries.

MARY

Can we talk?

Behind Joseph, the work begins to stop.

Caleb starts toward them.

Malachi catches his arm.

CALEB

What?

Malachi gives him a look.

CALEB

Right.

Levi looks at Joseph.

Joseph gives him the smallest nod: I've got it.

LEVI

We'll finish tomorrow.

JOSEPH

All right.

The men begin putting down and gathering their tools.

Levi starts to leave, then turns back.

LEVI

Joseph.

Joseph looks at him.

LEVI

Tomorrow.

JOSEPH

Tomorrow.

Levi exits.

Ezra and Caleb follow.

Malachi lingers for only a moment.

MALACHI

We're here.

Joseph nods.

Malachi exits.

The rhythm that filled the room is gone.

Shira looks once more toward Mary.

Mary gives her a small nod.

I'm ready.

Shira exits.

TRANSITION INTO SCENE 6

Mary and Joseph are alone.

No blackout.

No ominous music.

The LED remains warm.

Nothing about Nazareth has changed.

The unfinished table remains.

The satchel Mary made is still on Joseph.

Everything Joseph believes his future will be is physically present around him.

He sets down the tool in his hand.

JOSEPH

Mary...

Beat.

JOSEPH

What happened?

Mary looks at him.

She remembers Shira's words.

Start with the truth.

MARY

I need to tell you something.

Scene 6 begins.